skills needed to secure a job. The result, he says, is a widening gap between what students are taught and what the job market demands. Students graduating from average colleges may complete their degrees without a clear understanding of skills required for the roles they are applying for. The problem, he believes, begins much earlier, with limited career counselling and inadequate exposure to changing industry requirements during the academic journey.

His friend and batchmate, Dev Sharma, says recruiters hiring for junior-level roles are looking beyond qualification and seeking candidates with at least the practical and technical skills needed to handle basic operations. "For students who have not been guided towards those skills during college, the gap becomes visible only when they enter the job market," Sharma says.

Both Negi and Sharma are on the lookout for jobs and continue to apply to various companies.

These issues were also highlighted in a recent report by global hiring platform Indeed, which revealed that India's young jobseekers are facing a more competitive and increasingly complex transition from education to employment, with 70% saying securing a first job is harder today than it was three to five years ago.

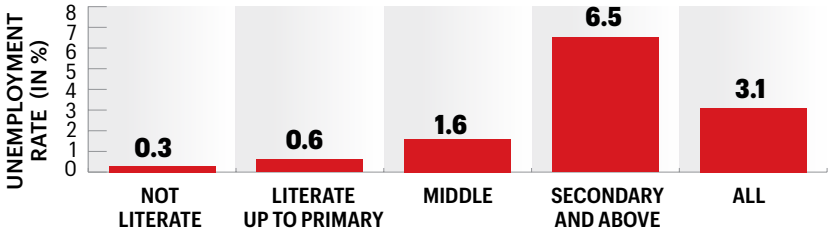
"New data from Indeed highlights how entry-level hiring expectations are evolving amid rising competition, limited career exposure opportunities and growing pressure on young professionals to compromise early in their careers," says Indeed's Fresher Hiring Report, based on a survey of 2,633 job seekers across India.

Sashi Kumar, Managing Director, Indeed India, says July saw an uptick in job creation on the platform after some softening in the previous three months. While there has been a slowdown in jobs in IT, roles for younger people are available in admin and sales support, education and service roles, commercial support, people-oriented functions even in the current reasonably tough job market, he says.

"Employers are looking for freshers who are upskilled, have good soft skills, can communicate well and function in a team environment," he says, adding that there's also a focus on having previous experience.

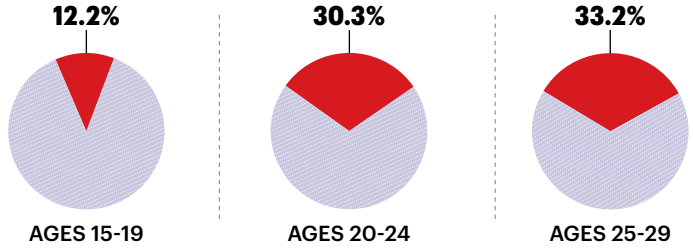
DEGREES DO NOT EQUAL JOBS

• Unemployment rises as one goes up the education chain



LARGE NUMBER OF YOUNG ADULTS IN NEET

• Persons not in education employment or training, or NEET, in 15-29 years age group (In %)



SOURCE PLFS 2025

THE JOB SEARCH

Estimates from the labour ministry show India likely created about 168.3 million jobs in the six-year period from FY18 to FY24. But these have clearly not been sufficient to meet its rising labour force, which is the second largest in the world with an estimated 7-8 million entrants annually.

The scale of the mismatch is stark. Data from the National Career Service (NCS) portal shows that by July 2026, there were 28.9 million active jobseekers registered while there were only 1.76 million active vacancies, showing the huge mismatch between jobs and candidates.

"For every one job vacancy, we send 20 potential candidates," says an official at a district employment exchange in Delhi, summing up the on-ground dynamics of jobs and jobseekers.

Walking into the office, it seems unusually empty. But the official says